Handout 1 — API Documentation Checklist

Getting Started with APIs and API Documentation
tekom 2026 · by Jordan Stanchev · www.jpdocu.com

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8 Elements to Document for Every API Endpoint

Use this checklist every time you document a new endpoint. An endpoint is not fully documented until all 8 are covered.

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1. Endpoint

- HTTP method: GET / POST / PUT / DELETE / PATCH
- Path: the URL after the base URL, e.g. /users/{id}
- Full example URL: https://api.example.com/v1/users/42

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2. Description

- One or two sentences: what does this endpoint **do**?
- Write for a developer who has never seen it before
- Avoid restating the method and path — add meaning instead

Bad: "GET /users returns users."
Good: "Returns a paginated list of all active users in your organization."

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3. Authentication

- Is authentication required? Yes / No
- Type: API key / OAuth 2.0 / Bearer token / Basic auth / None
- Where does it go? Header / Query parameter / Request body
- Example header: Authorization: Bearer {your_token}

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4. Request parameters

Document every parameter the caller can pass:

Name	Location	Type	Required	Description
id	Path	string	Yes	Unique identifier of the resource
limit	Query	integer	No	Max number of results to return (default: 20)

- **Path parameters** appear in the URL: /users/{id}

- **Query parameters** appear after ?: /users?limit=10
- Always state the default value for optional parameters

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5. Request body

- Required for POST, PUT, PATCH — usually JSON
- List every field: name, type, required/optional, description
- Include a complete example

If the endpoint uses GET or DELETE with no body, write: *No request body.*

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6. Response body

- Show the success response (HTTP 200 or 201)
- Include a real JSON example
- Document every field in the response: name, type, what it means

Do not just list field names — explain what the value represents.

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7. Error codes

The section developers read first when something breaks.

Code	Meaning	Common cause
400	Bad Request	Missing required parameter or invalid format
401	Unauthorized	Missing or expired authentication token
404	Not Found	Resource with that ID does not exist
429	Too Many Requests	Rate limit exceeded
500	Internal Server Error	Problem on the server side

Document every error code your API actually returns — not just generic HTTP codes.

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8. Rate limits

- How many requests are allowed per time window?
- Example: 100 requests per minute per API key
- What happens when the limit is exceeded? (HTTP 429 + retry guidance)
- Is there a way to check remaining quota? (e.g. response headers)

Quick reminder: what good description looks like

Field name	Bad description	Good description
created_at	The created at timestamp	ISO 8601 timestamp of when the resource was created, in UTC
status	The status	Current state of the request: pending, active, or closed
user_id	The user ID	Unique identifier of the user who created this resource

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Keep this card. It works for any API you will ever document.

Handout 2 — Exercise 1: Explore an API Endpoint

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Your task

You will access a live public API and document one endpoint. No account or login required.

API: JSONPlaceholder — a free, public REST API for testing
Base URL: https://jsonplaceholder.typicode.com

Step 1 · Pick an endpoint

Choose one endpoint from the list below. Open it in your browser or Postman.

Endpoint	What it returns
GET /posts/1	One blog post
GET /users/1	One user profile
GET /todos/1	One to-do item
GET /comments/1	One comment
GET /albums/1	One photo album

Your chosen endpoint: _____

Step 2 · Make the request

Open your browser and go to:

https://jsonplaceholder.typicode.com + your endpoint path

Example: https://jsonplaceholder.typicode.com/posts/1

You will see a JSON response in the browser window.

Step 3 · Fill in the form

HTTP method: _____

Full URL: _____

Authentication required? Yes No (circle one)

What does this endpoint do? *(one sentence — your own words)*

Response fields — list every field you see in the JSON response:

Field name	Data type	What does this field mean?

HTTP status code returned: _____

Step 4 · Reflect

What would a developer need to know about this endpoint that is NOT obvious from the response alone?

You'll use this endpoint again in Exercise 2.

Handout 3 — Exercise 2: Write a Reference Topic

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Your task

Write a complete API reference topic for one endpoint from JSONPlaceholder.
Use a **different endpoint** than the one you documented in Exercise 1.

Goal: A publishable draft — clear, complete, ready for a developer to use.

Reference topic template

Fill in every section. If a section genuinely does not apply, write *None* — do not leave it blank.

[HTTP METHOD] /path/to/endpoint

Replace the line above with the actual method and path, e.g.: GET /posts/{id}

Description

One or two sentences. What does this endpoint do? Write for someone who has never seen it.

Request

Base URL: https://jsonplaceholder.typicode.com

Authentication: _____

Parameters

List all path and query parameters. If none, write "None."

Name	Location	Type	Required	Description
	Path / Query		Yes / No	
	Path / Query		Yes / No	
	Path / Query		Yes / No	

Request body

For GET and DELETE endpoints, write "None."

Response

Success

HTTP status code: _____

Example response:

{

paste your actual JSON response here

}

Response fields:

Field	Type	Description

Error codes

List the error codes this endpoint can return.

Code	Meaning	When it occurs
404	Not Found	

Example request

Write the full URL a developer would use to call this endpoint.

https://jsonplaceholder.typicode.com _____

Pair review checklist

When you swap with a partner, check:

- [ ] Description explains what the endpoint does — without repeating the method and path
- [ ] Every response field has a meaningful description (not just the field name restated)
- [ ] At least one error code is documented
- [ ] Authentication section is filled in (even if "None required")
- [ ] The example request URL works — paste it in a browser to verify

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Reference: use Handout 1 (8-element checklist) if you get stuck on what to include.

Handout 4 — API Vocabulary Reference Card

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Core concepts

API (Application Programming Interface)
A defined way for two systems to communicate. You send a request; the API sends back a response. Think of it as a waiter: you order from the menu (request), the kitchen prepares the food (server), the waiter brings it back (response).

REST API
The most common type of API on the web. Uses standard HTTP methods and URLs. Responses are usually in JSON format.

Endpoint
A specific URL that performs a specific action. Each endpoint = one thing the API can do.
Example: https://api.example.com/users/42

Base URL
The root address shared by all endpoints of an API.
Example: https://api.example.com — all endpoints start here.

HTTP Method
The verb that tells the API what action to take:

Method	Action
GET	Retrieve data
POST	Create a new resource
PUT	Replace an existing resource
PATCH	Update part of an existing resource
DELETE	Remove a resource

Request anatomy

Request
A message you send to an API asking it to do something. Contains: method, URL, headers, and optionally a body.

Path parameter
A variable embedded in the URL path, identified by {curly braces}.
Example: /users/{id} — the {id} is replaced with a real value: /users/42

Query parameter
Additional options added to the URL after a ?.
Example: /posts?limit=10&page=2

Request body
Data sent with POST, PUT, or PATCH requests, usually in JSON format. Contains the content you want to create or update.

Header
Metadata sent alongside a request. Most commonly used for authentication.
Example: Authorization: Bearer eyJhbGciOiJIUzI1N...

Authentication
Proof that you are allowed to use the API. Common types:

- **API key** — a string you include in a header or query parameter
- **Bearer token** — a short-lived token, usually from an OAuth login
- **Basic auth** — username and password, encoded in the header

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Response anatomy

Response
What the API sends back after processing your request. Contains: a status code and usually a body.

HTTP status code
A three-digit number that tells you whether the request succeeded or failed:

Range	Meaning	Common examples
2xx	Success	200 OK, 201 Created, 204 No Content
4xx	Client error (your fault)	400 Bad Request, 401 Unauthorized, 404 Not Found, 429 Too Many Requests
5xx	Server error (their fault)	500 Internal Server Error, 503 Service Unavailable

Response body
The data the API returns, usually in JSON format.

JSON (JavaScript Object Notation)
The most common format for API data. Human-readable, structured as key-value pairs.

```
{
  "id": 1,
  "title": "Introduction to APIs",
  "published": true
}
```

Documentation concepts

API reference
Technical documentation for every endpoint: method, URL, parameters, request/response examples, error codes. Developers consult it for exact syntax.

Developer guide
Conceptual and procedural documentation: getting started, tutorials, how-to guides. Developers read it when building something new.

OpenAPI / Swagger
A standard format for describing a REST API in a machine-readable file (YAML or JSON). Many tools can auto-generate reference documentation from an OpenAPI spec.

Rate limit
A cap on how many API requests you can make in a given time window. Example: 100 requests per minute. Exceeding the limit returns HTTP 429.

Keep this card for future reference. These terms apply to virtually every REST API you will ever document.